3

An Invitation to Listen

My mother called me a *nosy child*. I would place an empty glass against a closed door to hear adult conversations. I would hold mail up to the light to catch a glimpse of what was inside the envelope. I kept binoculars on my bedside table and stared into our neighbor's bedroom. I would piece together evidence and observe patterns. I would notice when a piece of information—however innocuous—was withheld.

It was no help that my father was compulsively private. He would take conversations in the basement—"Hold on," he would say to whomever was on the other end of the call—and then he would walk slowly downstairs to the mildewy basement with its peeling green walls. He called this dimly lit space his office. He had a desk that could barely fit a legal pad, an answering machine, two perfectly sharpened pencils, and an exercise mat that he would unroll on Sundays to do push-ups. And it is from that desk that he would "take a call," in what seemed to me to be a conspiratorial whisper. I would stand on the other side of the shut door. I would close my eyes so that I could focus on listening. I felt if I closed my eyes as tightly as I could stand, the sound would improve.

It was also no help that for much of my adolescence, my parents were in the long middle of their marriage, a time when it seemed that our family might not hold. As an only child, my survival, I thought, hinged on eaves-

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dropping. I would listen to my parents' whispered fights to try to gather some sense of what the future, *our* future, might hold. Even in the moment when my parents and I hugged each other in front of my freshman dorm on Massachusetts Avenue, we collectively set off into a future that was entirely unknowable. I could not fathom what might happen to them, to us. I didn't know if they would find something to sustain them beyond their shared Black middle-class aspirations for future generations—for me, really. My father and I are the only people on this earth who remember that time, and it is the one thing we do not discuss. As the years have passed, we have become more alike: our preoccupations, our identically shaped bodies and patterns of speech. But this remains the silence between us: the story of what almost happened between my parents, and how it didn't happen.

Nosy child, nosy adult. I always wondered about the shoebox in my parents' basement, the one where my father—the family archivist—had kept (in chronological order) every letter my mother mailed him from Vassar College. Truth be told, he was with her for much of the time she was a student at Vassar. He would hitchhike to Poughkeepsie from New York City every week. He was there often enough that many of my mother's classmates thought he was one of the few men enrolled in what Vassar describes as its first fully coeducational class.[1] My father was two years older than my mother, but he had spent his first and second years of college moving from school to school (he is the only person who holds the history of why this happened, and it is one that he seems reluctant to share). By the time he met my mother—the summer before her first year at Vassar—he was prepared to begin his freshman year again at City College of New York. There was no courting, really. From what they tell me, he declared himself her boyfriend, and she accepted. He spent the next four years hitchhiking back and forth from New York City to Poughkeepsie, until he saved enough money to buy a small yellow car that made a ticking noise. My mother reports she could hear my father a few blocks away, and it allowed her enough time to slip her jacket on and get outside before his car rolled up. From what I can tell, the few days each week when she was left to the company of her friends and the ordinary rhythms of school, she would write to my father. These letters lived in my parents' basement for forty years.

That box of letters had always been tantalizing. I knew of its existence, but I had also heard my father's warning: *That box is private*. I have long wanted to see their romance, to have access to a story of the immensity of their affection in the years before their shared project became launching me. My mother's Vassar yearbook is a testament to the sexual revolution unfolding

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in real time. I grew up flipping through it and my impression of college was formed by it—many of her classmates posed naked in their senior photos. My mother's picture appears toward the back of the book on a page called "just regular folks." She wears a black turtleneck with a silver sequined spiderweb across her chest. Her hair is long and ironed straight, parted in the middle, a gesture to the times—this was 1974. Everything else, though, is against the moment: the turtleneck and the embarrassed smile. I hoped that in the shoebox, in those letters, she might seem as unbuttoned as her classmates appeared in those pictures: desirous, playful, sexual. But I never approached that box in my parents' house, despite my will to read, my desire to know.

The shoebox of letters didn't make it to Chapel Hill, North Carolina, when my parents left—*escaped* might be the right word—their life in New Jersey, and the house that was organized around their working lives in New York City, professional identities that were shed with their respective retirements. Somehow, they packed up forty years of brochures, plastic bags, good-enough wire hangers, outdated clothing, and about thirty dozen small bottles of hotel shampoo and conditioner and moved it to North Carolina, where I spent the good part of a summer sorting it. My father was in a frenzy at the end of their month of packing. The final boxes he packed are a testament to his fatigue; one contained four wire hangers, some trash bags, a collection of seashells, and a Nutribullet. What I don't know is what happened to the shoebox, if it was tossed into a dumpster or if it remains hidden somewhere in the small storage unit in the basement of their new apartment building. What I have found is just one letter, this one penned not by my mother but by my father.

Imagine what I discovered: He was then as he is now. His letter is marked by a deep and sustained attention to the mundane. My father has long been attuned to the portions of a story that the rest of us edit out: standing in line in a store, the price of gasoline, the pothole on the corner, the circular that came in the mail, a credit card that was applied for, a coupon promising a minuscule discount. Life lived on the small scale.

I often tell a story of my first trip to India, waking up in my in-laws' house—disoriented and jet-lagged—to the sound of cawing crows and the distant pounding of hammering. I called my father and said, "Dad, we're here." And he said, "Good, good. Now I want to tell you something important. Remember that pothole on the corner of Cranford and Grayson?" He waits as if about to deliver the punch line of a joke: "It's still there, Jen. It's still there."

So here I am: I wanted access to something about my mother, an archive of her barely post-adolescent desire, and I instead encounter my father. I am

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left only to imagine my mother, the letter's recipient, opening the envelope and reading his careful cursive. How did a twenty-year-old woman interpret her boyfriend's steadfast commitment to the mundane? Was it a sign of his reliability, his commitment to the everyday, or perhaps a sign of his dullness? It is a fantasy to think I could have ever asked these questions and gotten answers, of course.

But there is no posing these questions now.

Last night we ate Chinese takeout. My mother opens the Styrofoam containers and scoops eggplant and basil onto her plate. She eats happily and then looks lovingly at me and compliments me on the meal she thinks I have prepared. I am elated that she has enjoyed the food. I am devastated that she has already forgotten that I haven't cooked this food. Life is filled with the evidence of slowly losing her.

This is when my eavesdropping impulse is at its strongest. And yet I know it cannot be satisfied. Now I cannot press my ear to any doors. There is nothing to listen to that will offer me a glimpse into the past. Instead, there is one letter and all my desires to hold on to the present and to touch the past, to have what feels like one last chance to get to know my mother.

Forms of Address

In 2019 Imani Perry published *Breathe*. The book is a letter addressed to her sons, Freeman and Issa, and is animated by a mother's abiding wish for her sons to keep breathing. This is a wish voiced in a moment when "I can't breathe" had become a rallying call for the movement for Black life and a collective "wake work." Perry's *Breathe* is a letter written in anticipation of loss, one that treats preparation for grief as the hallmark of contemporary Black maternal life. Perry writes, "Something distinct has happened in your time. It is the product of camera phones, the diminishing whiteness of America, the backlash against a Black presidency, the persistence of American racism, the money-making weapons industry, the value added of murder in police dossiers, law-and-order policing."[2] This is a familiar story: about Black sons, about the times we live in and how they are both a deep continuation of the past and distinct in the new visibility of Black death. This story takes on what has now become a familiar Black feminist form: the letter.

Five years earlier, in August 2014, Sybrina Fulton—Trayvon Martin's mother—published a letter to Michael Brown's family in *TIME* magazine.[3] The letter was written two years after Martin was fatally shot and a year after

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George Zimmerman was acquitted of second-degree murder and manslaughter in Martin's death. It was published two weeks after Michael Brown's murder, in the days when Ferguson, Missouri, became synonymous with a newly visible Black Lives Matter movement and with what many news sources decried as "civil unrest."[4] Fulton described the immensity of her grief at the fact that the Brown family would "join this exclusive yet growing group of parents and relatives who have lost loved ones to senseless gun violence."[5] She advised them to "surround yourselves with proven and trusted support. . . . I have always said that Trayvon was not perfect. But no one will ever convince me that my son deserved to be stalked and murdered. No one can convince you that Michael deserved to be executed."[6] And she suggested—as she did many times in the months following her son's murder—that her son's death was the birth of her political consciousness.[7] She instructed the Brown family, "If they refuse to hear us, we will make them feel us. . . . [F]eeling us means feeling our pain; imagining our plight as parents of slain children."[8]

These two letters—one taking the form of a book and one published in a magazine—are my point of departure in this chapter. I study how Black feminists use the form of the letter to make Black loss—particularly Black maternal loss—"felt" by its readers. This body of work insists that the form of the letter makes Black maternal loss particularly feelable by transporting its reader to the scene of loss.[9] In the book's first chapter, I talked about how the beautiful voice this book centers is made through repetition, and this chapter thinks about how ubiquitous the letter form has become, how it is now the primary vehicle for describing Black loss to a broad public. If Jack Hamilton describes the "open letter" as "the most overused mode of contemporary writing, a one-sided conversation with someone famous in which the performative bypass of audience creates an aloof sort of anti-intimacy," Emily Lordi insists that "for black writers in particular, working in an embattled political moment, the epistolary form offers a way to address the effects of racial oppression without centering those who perpetuate and benefit from it."[10] I draw on Lordi's insights on the importance of the letter in an "embattled political moment," tracing how Black feminists strategically deploy the letter to produce intimacy and proximity with readers, to transport readers to the scene of loss, to make Black maternal grief "feelable."[11]

In making this claim, I ask how contemporary Black feminist authors work to transform their readers into eavesdroppers. They invite readers to get as close as possible to a whispering voice. Letters allow their readers to have the sensation—perhaps exciting, perhaps risky, perhaps uncomfort-

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able—of reading something that didn't anticipate them. Of course, these letters *did* anticipate a broad reading public, as in the case of Perry's book or Fulton's *TIME* magazine publication. But the form of the letter allows readers to feel—however fleetingly—that they are encountering something that did not foresee their readership. The feeling of being an eavesdropper is a device, and a profound one, that Black feminists have mobilized with a particular intensity in the period of Black Lives Matter. And it is a device that has been deployed precisely because it is imagined to render Black loss knowable in a distinct way.

In using the term *eavesdropping*, I recognize that I deploy it differently than others. I am describing the act of *reading* something that did not anticipate us rather than hearing something that did not anticipate us as a practice of eavesdropping. Or perhaps I am suggesting that the act of reading and the act of listening are simply not that distinct. If in the first chapter, I talked about how beautiful writing is marked by various forms of seduction, the letter makes this particularly visible. Readers are allowed to feel—encouraged to feel, even—like they are accessing an intimate conversation that did not intend their listening. But, of course, the letter is consciously constructed and staged, performed for its reader, all the while hiding its performative qualities.

My understanding of eavesdropping is informed by Krista Ratcliffe's celebration of eavesdropping as a "tactic for listening to the discourse of others, for hearing over the edges of our own knowing, for thinking what is commonly unthinkable within our own logics."[12] For Ratcliffe, eavesdropping is a feminist tactic aligned with listening, "world-traveling," and attending to a politics of location.[13] I think about eavesdropping differently, treating it not entirely in the romantic register of resistance. While I think eavesdropping can invite forms of generative listening, I am also curious about why Black maternal pain must be made feelable in certain ways to be visible, to be engaged. I also explore the kinds of Black loss that become consumable (and marketable), the kinds that the letter repeats. I am equally interested in why Black feminists want readers to *feel* like they are "hearing over the edges of [their] own knowing." I aspire to understand why Black feminists have steadfastly imagined that making Black women's losses knowable—something that is imagined as a necessary precondition to a cultural recognition of Black women's full and "complex personhood"—requires Black women to lay bare their secrets, or at least to pretend to do so.[14] Thus I sit with Lordi's important insight that the epistolary is always marked by the "demand that writers balance two aims: of 'enlightening' the dominant culture and of

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sharing tactics of survival with loved ones and others under siege."[15] I think about how contemporary Black feminist writers negotiate these competing demands and how they grapple with a complex wish to render Black maternal loss knowable to a broad public.

The archive of contemporary Black feminist letters that I think with here builds on and reinterprets the intellectual and political insights of Ta-Nehisi Coates's celebrated *Between the World and Me* (2015). Following James Baldwin's *The Fire Next Time*, Coates's book is a letter written to his fifteen-year-old son. *Between the World and Me* was penned in direct response to the enduring conditions of racism and the newly visible conditions of anti-Black violence (the publisher moved its release date earlier, so that the book could circulate in the wake of the white supremacist mass shooting committed by Dylann Roof in a Charleston, South Carolina, church in 2015). Coates begins his letter with a diagnosis of the present moment, which has inaugurated a new global consciousness of Black death and a new market for literary works that document Black mourning. He writes, "This was the year you saw Eric Garner choked to death for selling cigarettes; because you know now that Renisha McBride was shot for seeking help, that John Crawford was shot down for browsing in a department store. And you have seen men in uniform drive by and murder Tamir Rice, a twelve-year-old child whom they were oath-bound to protect."[16] Garner, McBride, Crawford, and Rice are, for Coates, key entries in a contemporary glossary of Black death. Their names are ways of narrating a present moment marked by the simultaneous not-newness of Black death and the newness of cultural attention to Black death. They are also a way of narrating his son's emerging consciousness of the precarity of Black life, and of instructing his son on American "heritage": a predilection for "destroy[ing] the black body."[17] Ultimately, Coates presents his son—his readers, really—with what he calls the "question of my life": "how one should live within a black body, within a country lost in the Dream."[18] How, he asks, can his son, and his readers, live in history, *with* a recognition of American "inheritance," and carve out a space for Black living, self-invention, and tenderness?

Coates's book—his wish for his son's freedom expressed as a letter—became the defining text of the early days of Black Lives Matter, what Brit Bennett described as "a crucial book during this moment of generational awakening."[19] And it is one that used the form of the letter—the pretense of an intergenerational conversation between a father and son—to allow its reader to eavesdrop, to hear a conversation about dispossession, violence, anticipation, and grief. Michelle Alexander highlights Coates's use of address and construction

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of audience in her review of the book. She notes that *Between the World and Me* is "not addressed to white people. The usual hedging and filtering and softening and overall distortion that seems to happen automatically—even unconsciously—when black people attempt to speak about race to white people in public is absent."[20] Of course, the book *did* anticipate white readers, and Hamilton insists that the book is "written toward white Americans, and I say this as one of them. White Americans may need to read this book more urgently and carefully than anyone, and their own sons and daughters need to read it as well."[21] What made *Between the World and Me* distinctly able to speak Black loss differently was that it took the form of an intimate conversation. It allowed its readers to *feel* as if they were eavesdropping on a conversation that they may—or may not—have access to otherwise. This proximity allowed readers to encounter familiar terrain anew, with a new sense of an intimate understanding of anti-Black violence. *Between the World and Me* has since become central to the anti-racist reading project of 2020 (which, by 2022, when I write this chapter, had already begun to disappear).[22]

In the years since Coates's celebrated book was published, in the midst of what has been described as a Black Lives Matter literary market, Black feminists have laid claim to the epistolary and made it a primary form for naming and describing a particular kind of Black maternal loss, for ensuring that this loss is seen and felt. To be clear, I begin with Coates not to suggest that he inaugurated a form that Black feminists have copied; instead, I track how Black feminists have deployed and remade the form of the letter, harnessing its intimate power and centering the Black maternal as the key icon of Black loss. This is not simply a "say her name" response to Coates's masculinist approach—an ethics that was highlighted and critiqued even as the book was celebrated.[23] It is a deployment of the form of the letter, and its performance of intimacy, to fundamentally restage the paradigmatic Black loss *not* as the Black father losing his Black son but as the Black mother losing her Black son.

This chapter begins by thinking more deeply about the letter and its prominent place in a Black feminist Black Lives Matter archive. I am particularly invested in the letter's promise to bring us to the scene of loss, and in the kinds of loss that are revealed to readers, and in the ways that all of this unfolds through the pretext of intimacy. The remainder of the chapter thinks about other ways the Black feminist letter might work, to think loss differently with a particular attention to the ordinary, the quiet, the quotidian. I study Julietta Singh's *The Breaks*, an extended letter to her daughter. Singh draws on Black feminist theory—particularly Saidiya Hartman's

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Lose Your Mother—to think rigorously and beautifully about forms of nonspectacular, durational, and ordinary loss and to reimagine loss as anticipated and expected but also welcome and generative. When I describe my desire to think apart from the now dominant performance of Black loss, it is not an impulse to critique or condemn Black feminist work on grief and loss, particularly on the anticipated loss of Black sons. Instead, I want to think with Black feminist theory to open up space for other kinds of Black loss and grief, those that are ordinary, complicated, surprising, and those that move in slow motion. I want to make room for forms of Black loss that have different relationships to privacy and publicity, those that refuse spectacle and are inhabited in the everyday, which might make them take on different registers and shapes. I turn to Singh's work, then, not out of a desire to supplant or replace Black feminist texts that offer us important ways of thinking about the conditions of the present, but instead because it points us toward the complex and multifaceted itineraries of loss. I look to Singh's book to think with performances of loss and intimacies of loss that center unknowability, uncertainty, mystery, and even forms of pleasure and solidarity.

Black Feminist Letters

The letter has become ubiquitous, a device for naming forms of Black grief and anticipated loss. Like "the talk"—often described as the painful conversation Black parents are required to have with their children, particularly their sons, about navigating routine anti-Black state violence—the letter has become a well-traveled form allowing a constructed public display of Black pain and grief, a way of describing the temporality of anticipation. While I mention "the talk"—another entry in a larger cultural lexicon of Black grief—the talk operates differently than the letter. On an NPR episode devoted to the talk, Kenya Young notes:

> I'll never forget there was a time—the kids wanted to go to the park. This was right around the time of Philando Castile and Alton Sterling. My third son was just born. And I had many moments where I was holding him or nursing him and crying as I did so. Because, while I loved this little bundle of joy immensely, also just the amount of fear and worry for who I just brought into the world again, another Black son, and the burdens that I have to carry with that again. It was really raw for me around that time.[24]

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For Young, the talk is a shorthand for a required form of Black maternal vigilance. The talk is a way of describing the dreaded parental labor of preparing children for forms of violence that are expected and routinized, and a shorthand for detailing how Black children are robbed of the idea of childhood innocence that continues to structure whiteness.[25]

But the letter shifts us from a description of a conversation between parents and children to an opportunity for readers to *hear* that conversation—or at least to feel that they are hearing it. Eavesdropping. This is a performance of an intimate conversation between mothers and children made visible for readers' consumption. And the letter has proliferated, appearing in magazines, newspapers, and books, and read aloud on radio stations, making eavesdropping a prevailing experience of engaging Black loss.[26] In "A Radical Love Letter to My Son," for example, Sarah Mantilla Griffin speaks directly to her son: "In the wake of the killing of Trayvon Martin and the acquittal of his killer, my phone, email, and Facebook feed lit up with the concerns of mothers like myself, asking: how do we keep our children safe? . . . Loving you—who will constantly be at risk of physical and psychological injury—is perilous, but I wholeheartedly believe that it is a powerful way to enable you to be whole."[27] Griffin details the "risk" of Black mothering of Black boys: the threat of loss paired with the decision to move forward with "radical" love, a form of love that requires "nothing less than our selves in the pursuit of a revolution that begins with our children's mental and physical health and ends with those children transforming our country and our world."[28] But she insists, as she writes in the first sentences of the letter, "I love you. I have chosen how to love you. I love you radically, and I hope that this love will keep you free."[29]

Joy Sewing's editorial in the *Houston Chronicle*, also in the form of a letter to her son, begins with the acknowledgment that he cannot understand the letter she is writing. She notes, "At just 4, you are too young to understand what his death has meant to the world, too young to know that his [Martin's] life amplified dissidence."[30] In fact, her son becomes a literary device, one that allows her to imagine a future conversation that her readers can access, a conversation about living and loss, about anticipation and grief. What does it mean, her letter requires its readers to ask, to anticipate talking to a small child about state violence and future loss? Despite the fact that she notes her son cannot "understand what [Martin's] death has meant to the world," Sewing uses the letter to document the feelings of loss and anticipation that already mark her daily life, which she argues are constitutive of Black maternal life. The letter becomes a vehicle for capturing how loss already constitutes

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the present tense of Black maternal life. She writes, "I want to immerse myself into your soccer games and Cub Scouts meetings, your school dances and first dates. But they are all weighted in the reality that your life often is not considered to be of value. My job is to spread my arms wide to shield you from that."[31] To make oneself into a shield, Sewing notes, is the work of the Black maternal. And the everyday of Black maternal life is that soccer games and Cub Scouts meetings and the joyful banal become steeped in vigilance and anxiety. Reflecting on the anniversary of Martin's death, she reminds her son—her readers—"I wish I could say things are getting better, but that would not be true."[32] The form of the letter becomes a crucial way of naming the unchanging same with a different kind of intimacy, with the added emotional pull of imagining a mother describing loss, trauma, and grief to a child not yet old enough, perhaps, to fully understand the weight of that grief.

Perry's *Breathe* is part of this tradition: Perry speaks to her sons, describing what it means to mother them with the threat of imminent loss and to live with the singular wish for her sons to live on. It is an account of loss that is both rooted in the everyday and attuned to the spectacular, to how state violence erupts in and ruptures the ordinary. She writes, "The everyday. The homework, the cooking, the cleaning, the activities, the practices, the friends, the rearing, it is so much—even, or perhaps because of, the choices and things I have been afforded. And then, on top of that, the daily work of beating back the ugliness. And reconciliation with the irreconcilable. You live in some worlds that are more white than Black. And so, you learn, early on, that the aversion to Blackness can turn perfectly lovely people grotesque."[33] The anticipation that attends to Black mothering is embedded in "the cooking, the cleaning, the activities," it is routine, and yet as it is lived and feared, it is also spectacular. And while she refuses the logic of "this could have been my child," insisting that "my children are here, and they stand with me, to honor their dead," the book is about a wish that Elizabeth Alexander describes as "magical thinking," the wish for Black boys' living in the face of a world that thrives on devouring black people.[34]

And magical thinking, this genre reveals, is often about wishing, wanting, desiring in a world where Black dreaming is so often rendered impossible. Perry makes clear her own longings for her sons. She writes, "I want to hold you safe. I also want you to fly. . . . Yes, I am asking you to do something difficult. To make beauty and love in a genocidal time, with a harrowing past behind you."[35] The idea of flying Black boys channels Toni Morrison's *Song of Solomon* and Alexander's own image of dancing Black boys as an imagining of

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some kind of Black freedom, or at least an embodied representation of what Joshua Chambers-Letson calls "More Life."[36] Perry's wish is for mobility, for freedom in one's body, for the feeling of possibility and imagination. And she names other wishes for mobility, which seem to be central to mitigating loss; as she says, "I would like to take you to Africa one day. I am one of those Black people who believes in the value of return. However, you have already been to your ancestral home many times. It is the Deep South . . . The we to which you belong was born in the South of the United States."[37] Movement becomes a way of imagining something other than loss, grief, and death, a way of thinking about what Black life might look like if it were not already constituted by the ordinariness and regularity of violence.

And yet, at the very end of the book, Perry surprisingly breaks the form of the letter, addressing the reader directly about the decision to craft her book as a letter. This rupture feels surprising, jarring even, in a book that has allowed its readers to eavesdrop, to listen to Perry speak to her sons. It is this break that I want to sit with. She narrates a conversation where her editor asked her if she would be interested in writing a book that took the form of a letter to her sons. She writes, "I know the power of letters. I have received and written them my whole life."[38] The idea of letters as having a "power" comes, at least in part, from the intimate voice they construct, from how they whisper in their readers' ears. But even as she recognizes that letters wield a certain amount of power, that they mobilize intimacy for rhetorical force, she maintains that her letter is not merely a literary device, that "my sons are real in my life, and this is really for them."[39] In other words, while her sons appear on the page as characters, as literary and political devices that allow her to elaborate on anti-Blackness, they are, she contends, "real," and the book is "really for them," not for us, the readers, the eavesdroppers. Even as she insists on the particularity of her sons, and the book as an offering to her children, she also claims the general applicability of her book, noting, "If I had had your child instead of mine, the heart of what I said would repeat, though its elaboration moved by circumstance."[40] While Perry breaks from the letter here, she elaborates one of the most significant rhetorical moves the letter advances: it can at once insist on the radical specificity of its recipient and claim to speak broadly and generally. It is both about Perry's sons and about the precarity of all Black boys. It allows her to claim that "every second-person sentence devoted to them in these pages is to all of us. It is received wisdom from their witness and passionate hope for their futures."[41] The book can both address her sons and speak to "all of us" and our shared futures.

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There are, of course, substantial costs to the public performance of Black women's grief, costs that Perry has taken up in other forms outside of the letter. Indeed, I suggest that in her insistence that her book is about her "real in my life" sons, that the book is "really" written for them, Perry gestures to the complexities of Black performances of intimacy for public consumption, and even for a public anti-racist pedagogy. Perry's conversation with Samaria Rice, Tamir Rice's mother, finds Perry advocating that scholars and activists think critically about "hustling Black death." Perry writes, "In a sense, [Samaria] Rice wanted to maintain her authority over both her own voice and her son's legacy. To an extent, this was never possible. Although Tamir was her child, when we saw his sweet face emblazoned across our televisions, he became everyone's . . . She became particularly animated as she described those who make a living 'hustling Black death.' From where she sits, she sees 'book deals, movie deals.' Cocking her head to the side, as if speaking directly to her adversaries, she adds, 'What was you doing?'"[42] In posing the question "What was you doing?" Samaria Rice asks what happens when a child—*her* child—becomes "everyone's child," when one's grief becomes felt (or claimed to be felt) by so many. The notion of Tamir Rice as "everyone's child"—the notion of Black children as "community property"—has been a key strategy advocated not just by Perry but by others in their desire to claim some semblance of innocence for Black children, and in their collective impulse to ensure "More Life" for Black boys.[43] Indeed, in *Breathe*, Perry positions her sons as always fiercely her own, and also as characters who appear on the page to make a larger argument about the need to preserve Black male breath. Her sons appear in the form of the letter—which allows readers to intimately access anticipated pain—precisely because Perry wants us to imagine the terror of losing them, and the particular terror of approaching this fear repeatedly. But for Rice, this positioning of Black boys as collectively held is not exclusively a form of radical politics. It is also another theft, which she describes as "benefitting off the blood" of her child.[44] Rice emphasizes that the public performance of Black privacy—precisely the logic that undergirds the now ubiquitous Black feminist letter—actually produces its own set of losses. Her intervention requires us to ask, What happens when even your grief gets taken, or feels as if it is? Or when it circulates in ways that make it unrecognizable? This might be one version of what Dagmawi Woubshet describes as "compounding loss," but here the accumulation of loss happens in the name of Black freedom.[45]

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I offer Rice's critical and challenging queries about loss and ownership—and the economies that have sprung up around Black loss—without resolution. Instead, I see her words as requiring us to contend with the costs of performances of intimacy and proximity that render "real" dead and dying people community property whose names and stories can be circulated for a host of political reasons. As Rice suggests, when her son's name or image is used—regardless of political rationale—it is a theft; it is yet another experience of loss, a sense that even her grief is not her own. We might, then, think of whether the letter is its own "hustling" of Black death, one staged for making visible persistent violence, one enacted to give a name and a feeling to what Black women have long lived with. But it is, of course, a performance that allows its readers to get close, to eavesdrop, to feel a proximity to pain that may or may not be their own. And as Rice suggests, this performance requires, at the very least, that we grapple with its ethics, that we think about its consequences. It is a performance that asks that we contend with whether Black women's grief and loss might be feelable in other ways, made felt, made visible, and even with how we might contest the notion that we must show our wounds over and over again to prove their reality. It also requires that we think about the political desire to make Black loss feelable—for whom, and under what conditions.

Breaking

The Black feminist letter can also be used to offer conceptions of loss that emphasize the ordinary and the nonspectacular, the quiet and the processual, and that think about loss and its complex circuits differently. In this section I study Julietta Singh's *The Breaks* (2021). Singh draws on Hartman's analysis of Black historical loss to think about maternal loss as a productive *and* disruptive mode of living, as a form of self-making, and as a generative process of imagining a different and more livable world. To be clear, Singh is making a break from Hartman even as she builds on her work. If Hartman thinks about the collective Black loss of motherland and home—a loss that can never be repaired—Singh thinks about mother loss as "the political act of culling from history and discarding what does not serve you" and as a project of self-invention and self-forging.[46] Singh's work is indebted to Black feminist theory even as she emphasizes that she engages with a robust archive of Black feminist theoretical work as a brown mother, and as a brown mother of a brown daughter.

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Singh's *The Breaks* is an extended letter. But Singh writes to her daughter—not, as is the tradition of the Black feminist letter that I narrate, to a son. She begins by telling her daughter, "I am writing to you, and to future you. I am writing to the six-year-old girl you are now, the one who both insists on her unequivocal need for my body and loves to perform her independence from me."[47] The letter, Singh reveals, is always about writing to a present "you" and an imagined future "you," about the time she is in and a future time she imagines. And the future Singh imagines is a dark one—again, much as the other letters I write about here mark an anticipation of future destruction. But for Singh, this is a future marked by ecological catastrophe, by the collapse of democratic institutions, by our collective death. Singh is interested in the feeling of the inevitable destruction that awaits us, a destruction that is much of our own making. As she notes:

> I write not with the immediate fear that you will be gunned down by police in the streets, or that you will be metabolized by the prison industrial complex, but with an adjacent set of fears about being a Brown girl in a country that thinks and feels race through a sharp binary. I write with an impossible desire to prepare you for political and ecological catastrophe. . . . I write because, as mother and daughter, we are unmistakably entwined, and because I know—which is to say I feel in the most microbial registers of my body—that the shape of our environment will need to be radically reformed as we fight global patriarchy, extractive capitalism, and indiscriminate planetary destruction.[48]

While Singh carefully describes the fears she does not have—including an "immediate fear" that her daughter "will be gunned down by police in the streets"—she also captures the fears that she thinks mark the collective and her daughter: the slow and fast times of "political and ecological catastrophe."[49]

The notion of living in the ongoing time of disaster—a time that unfolds in slow motion and at quick speed—permeates her book, alongside a sense that generational struggle to remake the world and even generational rupture is required if life is to continue. In other words, the only response to the ongoing catastrophes of the present is to break, to imagine otherwise. This is a generational story for Singh: children must break from their parents, young people must break from older generations, the world must be remade and remade again, and this struggle is welcome and necessary. Breaks are nei-

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ther unexpected nor unwelcome; they are not necessarily forms of violence, though they can be experienced as injury and as ruptures that we grieve and mourn. But for Singh breaks are forms of living on that are particularly visible to mothers, who, she argues, are broken *from* by their children. The story she tells, in fact, about maternal life is that it is one of nurturing the breaks, of being ready for a maternal pain that she argues can be felt in a register adjacent to loss.

As Singh writes—channeling Hartman—"I know that we must lose our mothers, often only later (and in a perverse twist) to become them in ways we may not be able to predict or appreciate."[50] The sense that we *must* lose our mothers, that this loss is foundational and necessary, is a deep rearticulation of the dreaded anticipation of loss. For Singh, loss is expected, even if challenging and demanding. Singh's call to "lose our mothers" is not about violent capture and displacement, exile and racial violence; it is about differentiation and exploration, about self-imagining and self-fashioning. It is about self-making and world-making, and it is an insistence that some forms of loss are necessary for living on.

While Singh argues that we must "lose our mothers," make our own worlds apart from them, Singh's wish is that this break is staged with tenderness and care. She longs for breaks that produce something other than brokenness and perhaps even yield new forms of connection and love. This is the challenge of brown maternal life (and brown daughter life): to break gently, with tenderness and regard. As Singh writes, "Losing me, my way of life, is unquestionably a requisite to survival and futurity. Yet I hope with every thread of my being that this world-altering shift can become a form of breaking that does not sever us entirely, or wrench us into mutual unbelonging. My most intimate desire is that you find a way to break *with* me rather than to break *from* me. A desire in which the necessity of our breaking does not so much leave me behind in your struggle to survive as it invites me in and calls me to blaze alongside you."[51] While the break can be a form of loss, it can also be the beginning of new forms of relating and being together, what Singh calls an invitation to "blaze alongside you." What forms of relationality become possible when the hierarchical mother-daughter dyad is troubled, inverted, flipped, or wholly toppled? What does an invitation to "blaze alongside" each other look like when it is articulated from the vantage point of the daughter and felt from the position of the maternal? What might it mean to break in ways that do not produce "mutual unbelonging" but instead continue to make possible forms of urgent connection?

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I find this sense that mother and daughter—brown mother and daughter—can "blaze together" an account of the maternal very much in line with Alice Walker's early articulation of her relationship with her daughter, whom she imagines not as property or as someone she dominates, but instead as "sister." This is a model of reproduction as a practice of co-existence rather than as seeking our replacement or enacting a will to dominate.

This notion of breaking *with* rather than *from*—breaking as a form of generative rupture rather than catastrophic failure—is the utopian impulse of Singh's book. For Singh, brown mothering is distinct not in its proximity to loss but in its capacity to nurture the breaks and to see them as productive rather than threatening. Singh writes, "You now have been reared through an explicitly Brown maternity. For now, and for the most part, your orientations stem from mine. I imagine these orientations as rhizomes sending out little shoots that will lead you far away from me. I can't even begin to anticipate where they might take you. I want to offer myself to you as a base, not so that you can build yourself up from a fantasy of solid ground, but so you can discover the breaks, cracks, and sinkholes that constitute the lives that came before you."[52] An "explicitly Brown maternity" is one that recognizes mothering as "sending out little shoots that will lead you far away from me." It is a sense that mothering is about both proximity and distance as measurements of love. It is also a commitment to treating maternal flesh as a "base" for allowing other forms of living and breathing to take hold.

I think with Singh because of how she uses the letter to narrate a form of brown loss that does not (yet) appear in the letters that begin this chapter, and because of how this narration unfolds alongside Black feminist theory, including Hartman's signature work on race, kinship, and rupture. I think through how loss becomes something that Singh sees as necessary and life-affirming, even as it might also be threatening and overwhelming. This multivalent form of loss fascinates me precisely because it captures the multiple forms and affects that loss can generate, the way it can feel sustaining and devastating simultaneously. I am also invested in how Singh uses the familiar form of the letter—key to how Black feminists have made public seemingly private loss—to offer another iteration of racialized loss, to think about loss that is slow rather than spectacular, that is not about theft but about growth.

To lose your mother, Singh argues, is part of the process of brown mothering and daughtering, part of living with each other. The threat of the break is that it offers distance and no possibility of intimacy. The promise is that a new world is possible. We might think of this as capturing all that is both

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risky and thrilling about being together. As she tells her daughter, "I desire never to lose you, but for the sake of life itself, I need you to lose me. At the end of this world, you will rightfully be angry about what I am not yet prepared to reject in this age of purported freedom. But I hope your anger will not lead you to abandon everything that came before you, that it does not prevent you from culling what is of use from history for the future you will strive toward."[53] Singh's call for a generative form of slow breaking that is about reimagining the world is a different conception of loss; she recognizes that the breaks still might register as pain for Black and brown mothers, who, in Singh's imaginary, must live with the threat of "abandonment" and the fierce hope that "your anger will not lead you to abandon everything that came before you." But even with the specter of abandonment and loss, there is the idea of breaking *with*, an idea of loss that the dominant Black feminist voice rarely offers because of its rehearsal of a singular vision of loss that is spectacular and tethered to a singular event, where loss is violent theft. Ultimately, I turn to Singh's letter—and its investment in borrowing Hartman's conception of "lose your mother"—to consider how Black feminist theory can retain its investment in proximity and intimacy while troubling a paradigm of loss that makes Singh's vision of the breaks hard to see from within the parameters of Black feminist thought. How, Singh asks us, might loss be a precondition for rethinking the world? How might loss position brown and Black mothers not as forever-bereaved, as icons of grief, but as people whose experiences of loss engender new forms of relationality that may be uncertain, uncomfortable, still-becoming? How might we think about loss as part of the fabric of the quotidian, as a precondition of being together? And what might happen if we think loss in multiple valences, and anticipation in multiple valences, including its ordinary and spectacular iterations, and the multiple forms of harm and possibility it can engender?

Ordinary Letters

My move to Chicago was the very first time that I did not have my eyes on my parents. I was a new parent juggling the relentless demands of a small child. I was a newly tenured professor juggling the relentless demands of a new job. In the three years that I spent in Chicago, I could see—*feel*—my mother receding. By the time I flew from Chicago to New Jersey to accompany my mother to her first visit to a neurologist—a visit I commemorated with a singular photograph, a view of an icy Chicago from the airplane, a picture I

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sent to my husband from the runway of Midway International Airport with the caption "mistakes were made"—I already knew what the diagnosis was.

I broke from, I moved from, and I realized we could not live that way. I quickly learned that a future of us aging across time zones and flying distances wasn't tenable. It was a time that was saturated with loss: some so large that they are catastrophic—my mother's diagnosis—and some so small that I don't even know how to characterize them except to describe an image: my office perched on the top of a modern building, a view of downtown Chicago and the lake, everything about it promised: *You have made it*. And yet I would also tell myself, *Nothing can happen for me here*.

You know this story. I have already narrated it here. I moved, my parents moved, and we ended up together living in a place none of us ever imagined. But this isn't a story of having been saved. It is a story about my abiding curiosity about all that has already been lost, and all the losses that are incorporated into the present, that sit in the room with me as I write this.

Which brings me to the letter that begins this chapter. My curiosities about my parents have been magnified by the temporality of anticipation. But for me, anticipation is not a time of waiting for a singular event but a longer anticipation of slow decline, loss in slow motion. We all age: my parents age, my daughter ages, I age. These processes that share the same name feel so different. I secure a job that comes with an embarrassingly long title; my daughter learns how to read; my parents' bodies seem to get smaller by the year.[54] This is all aging, all of it is time passing, but some of it reads as accomplishment and some of it feels like diminishment.

And I am confronted with my own desire to know, to have access to something I can no longer simply ask my mother about: *who was she* when she met my father, when she broke from her own parents. (She didn't really break with. She *escaped*, marrying my father a few weeks after her college graduation, telling me once, "It was live with my father or live with your father. I chose the latter.")

There are two things you should know: First, I am struck by my father's precise cursive. I have never—in my forty-two years of living—seen him use this form of writing, except when he elaborately signs his name on a check, a contract, or, in my childhood days, a credit card slip. And, second, you should know that my father can narrate his life through cars: a story about the cars he owned and those that were "company cars," those he drove in his life as a textbook salesman.

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This is a letter from April 1973, the spring of my mother's junior year, sixteen months before my parents' wedding. This is a letter that begins with "I miss you very much. So much so I was coming to see you yesterday but I decided not to."

Go on, I think.

And then it turns into a description of the impediments that kept my father from seeing my mother, namely, that he decided to polish his car.

He continues, "I polished the car yesterday. It looks very nice. I also used some ZIF to zif away the dirt on the front. ZIF never fails. I vacuumed the inners too." He reports on applying for a Gulf Oil card and on a book his professor recommended (*Mental Disorders in Urban Areas*), and before he signs off, tells her, "Lakers lost last night 117–109."

This is an account of the banal that lasted nearly fifty years in the archive of a New Jersey basement and that did not travel in a moving truck to North Carolina.

It is something that I imagined would be a love letter, an account of desire intensified by physical distance. It is instead a different kind of love letter, one that is suffused with the details of ordinary life (all life is ordinary life, I remind myself). It is a love letter that I only now understand as a grief object, as a symbol of loss, as I encounter it now, in the archive of everyday life. I come to it wanting to touch the past, to imagine my mother as she once was reading this, to imagine her young, alive, open to the world.

I see it for what it is: a description of my parents as they have always been, deeply committed to the ordinary. I see my father announcing his affection through the mundane. I imagine my mother learning to receive these quotidian details as a measure of love. I see my father as a young man forging some kind of freedom—a car, a gasoline credit card, a small TV on which to watch a game, a girlfriend in college in upstate New York. I imagine my mother as a young woman receiving what could be thought of as a love letter in her mailbox.

I see it for what it is: an archive of my own desire to capture a moment in which I didn't exist, a time I only describe as *before*, a moment in which my mother's life was opening in front of her. I see it for what it is: something that my father never intended would live on, in his forty-two-year-old daughter's hands (not to mention her book, one that he certainly will not read but certainly will buy to satisfy his own archival impulses), or that he thought would live on only in the form of his long conversation with my mother that has centered on the most ordinary, the stuff of life.[55]

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I find myself mourning, thinking of whatever it was they felt then for each other and where they are now, where what I see most profoundly is something I would call devotion. My father tends to my mother, albeit in his own idiosyncratic ways. He listens to her repeated questions, and answers her without frustration. He takes her for ice cream. He tells jokes that are unbearably corny but still amuse her. This isn't the kind of romance I sought in the archive, but it is one of a different sort: marked by attention and loyalty.

This study of letters, then, is a desire to think the place of the ordinary in Black life. It is a sustained rumination on Black living that centers the quotidian, in a Black feminist effort to restore the quotidian and the banal, the blearily ordinary, to Black people who still live as symbols of so much—whether pain or deviance, trauma or excess. My wish is for a Black feminist theory that can contend with this object—the letter that survives and its account of love announced through the mundane, encountered decades later in a season of slow loss—as an articulation of Black loss.

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